



The 90s Sitcom English Masterclass

Learning vocabulary, idioms, and
culture through *Friends* S1E13

*A visual guide to colloquial slang, clinical
psychology terms, and the anatomy of a 90s joke.*

Contextual Setup: The Episode Anatomy



Plot A (The Mishap)

- Chandler accidentally sees Rachel in the shower.
- Focus: Language of embarrassment, retaliation, and boundaries.

Plot B (The Psychoanalysis)

- Phoebe dates Roger, an overly analytical psychiatrist.
- Focus: Clinical vocabulary vs. everyday slang.

Plot C (The Family Secret)

- Joey discovers his father is having an affair.
- Focus: Idioms of truth, deception, and family dysfunction.

SCENE A

TEASER

INT. MONICA AND RACHEL'S APARTMENT - MORNING - (DAY 1)
(Chandler, Rachel)

CHANDLER ENTERS, LATE FOR WORK BUT HUNGRY. HE GRABS
A BITE OF HALF-EATEN MUFFIN FROM THE TABLE. THEN OPENS
THE FRIDGE AND STARTS HUNTING THROUGH IT. HE PULLS OUT
A CARTON OF ORANGE JUICE. **Vocabulary in Action** IM, RACHEL
IS HEADING TOWARD HER BEDROOM. SHE IS WRAPPING A
TOWEL SHE IS WRAPPING A TOWEL SHE IS WRAPPING A
DRINK FROM THE ORANGE JUICE. HE PULLS OUT
AROUND AND SEES HIM.

Bwaaaa! /

HE AVERTS HIS GAZE. RACHEL
COUCH AND COVERS HERSELF.

I'm sorry

I can't

guys, you

Theme 1: The Mishap & The Apology

Unbeknownst to him (Adverb phrase):
Without his knowledge.

Context: "Unbeknownst to him, Rachel is
heading toward her bedroom..."

Avert your gaze (Verb phrase): To
quickly look away from something
inappropriate or
embarrassing.

Context: Chandler panics and averts his
gaze when Rachel drops her towel."

The Anatomy of a Deflection

“That’s a relatively open weave. I can still see your, uh... **nippular** areas.”

Rule Breaking for Humor

Nipple + **-ular** = **Nippular**
(Noun) (Suffix) (Invented Adjective)

Chandler adds the suffix ‘-ular’ (like spectacular or cellular) to a taboo word to make it sound clinical and ridiculous, attempting to defuse a highly awkward situation.

“The One with the Boobles” Final Draft 12/16/94

CHANDLER
Can I just say one thing?
RACHEL

What?!

CHANDLER
That’s a relatively open weave
can still see your, uh... nippular
areas.

AS RACHEL ANGRILY COVERS UP...

FADE OUT.

Idiom:
Tit for Tat (noun)
A situation where
a harm or insult is
returned in kind;
evening the score.

Chandler
sees Rachel.



Rachel targets
Chandler...
but sees Joey.



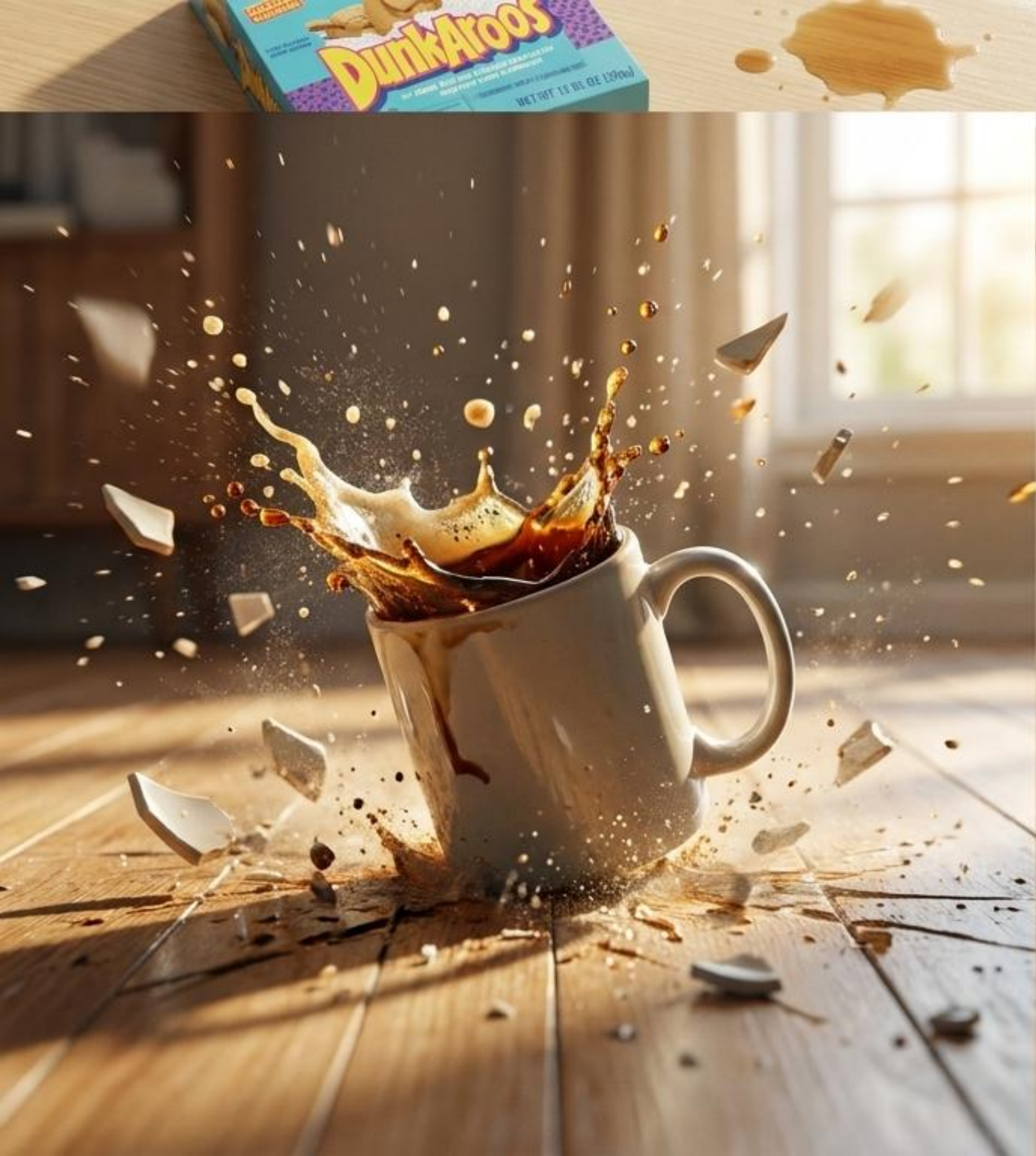
Monica targets
Joey...
but sees
Joey's Dad.



Joey targets
Rachel...
but sees
Monica.

TIT FOR TAT

Result: Total collateral damage.



Phrasal Verbs of Retaliation

“Clear the tracks for the Boobie Payback Express. Next stop... Rachel Green!”

- **Clear the tracks (Idiom):** To force everyone out of the way because something unstoppable is coming.
- **Payback (Noun):** An act of revenge for a past wrong.

Usage Note: Joey uses the metaphor of a speeding train ('Express') to show that his revenge cannot be stopped.

Theme 2: Enter 'The Shrink'

Formal Term:

Psychiatrist / Therapist.

Colloquial Slang:

"Shrink"

Action phrase: Air Quotes (noun)

Using two fingers on each hand to signal sarcasm or irony while speaking.

Context: Roger uses air quotes when mocking Chandler: "when the laughter stops".



Air Quotes (noun)
Doing two fingers on each hand to signal sarcasm or irony or irony while speaking.
Rogers not too, you know what...
(AIR QUOTES)
he's not too, you know... "shrinky".
(AIR QUOTES)
No, you not too, you in an embassy.
she are not using shrinky...
Chandler: "when the laughter stops".
Context: Roger uses air quotes

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PATIENT INTAKE FORM

Name: _____
Patient Code: _____
Appointment: _____

Roger's "Dysfunctional Dynamic" Diagnostic Matrix

Patient	Clinical Diagnosis	Behavioral Symptom
Chandler	Intimacy Issues / Defense Mechanism	Uses humor as a way of keeping people at a distance.
Ross	Codependent	Needs external love and validation (e.g., marrying a lesbian).
Monica	Middle-Child Syndrome	Desperately seeking approval (e.g., hoarding the Weeble Play Palace).



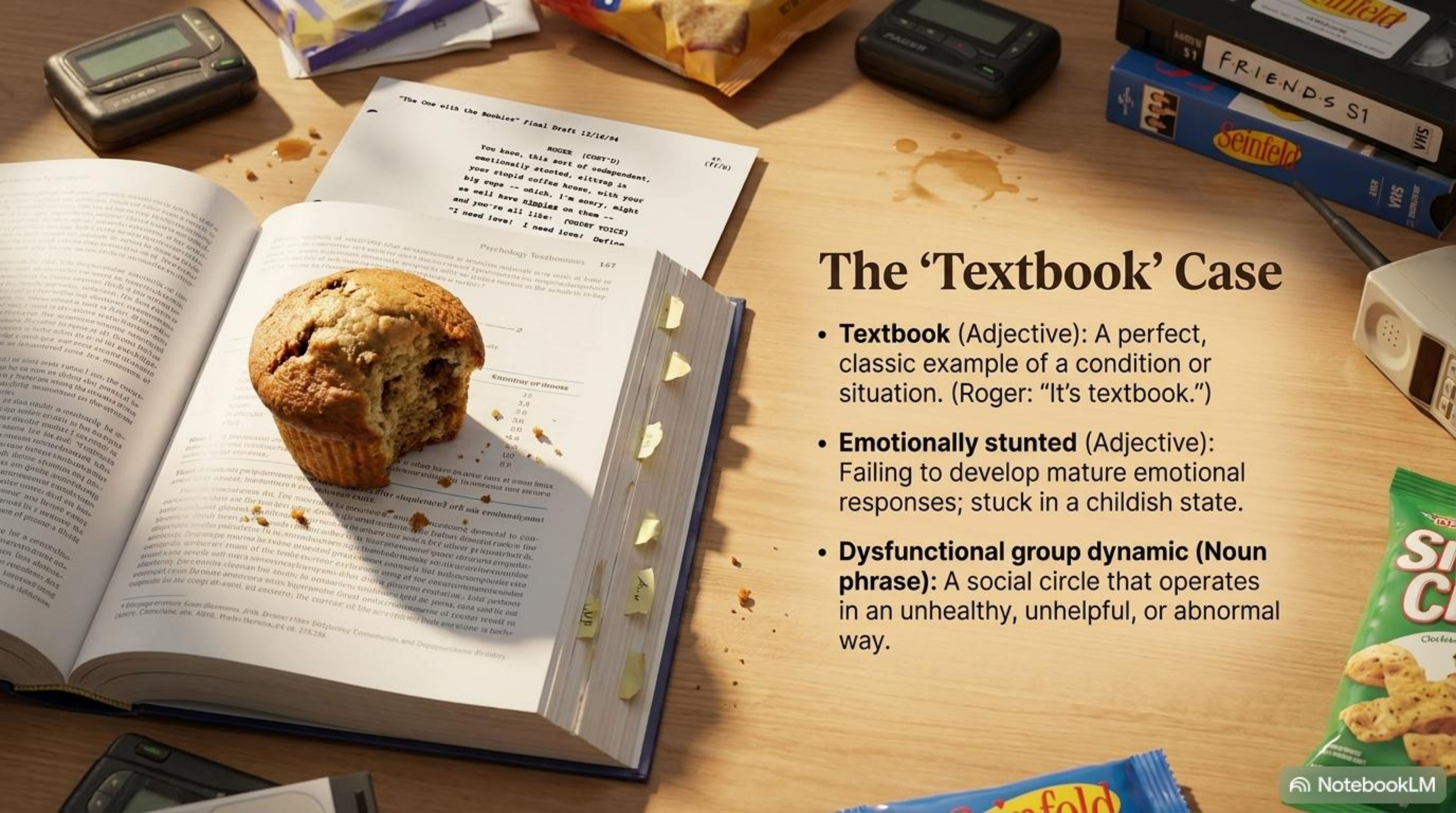
Deflection & Defense Mechanisms

→ “But hey, I just met you. I don’t know you from Adam.” ←

Idiom: Not know someone from Adam

To completely fail to recognize someone, or to emphasize that someone is a total stranger. Roger uses this to coldly distance himself after delivering a highly personal insult.

- **Keep at a distance:** To actively avoid emotional closeness.



The 'Textbook' Case

- **Textbook** (Adjective): A perfect, classic example of a condition or situation. (Roger: "It's textbook.")
- **Emotionally stunted** (Adjective): Failing to develop mature emotional responses; stuck in a childish state.
- **Dysfunctional group dynamic** (Noun phrase): A social circle that operates in an unhealthy, unhelpful, or abnormal way.

Theme 3: The Family Secret

1. Affair (Noun): A sexual or romantic relationship between two people, one of whom is married to someone else.

2. Restraining Order (Noun): A legal command requiring a person to stay away from someone they have harassed or abused.

Context: Joey mentions his sister's husband got one, highlighting the family's normalized chaos.





Idioms of Truth and Deception

The Lie

0-for-2 (Sports Idiom): Failing at two consecutive attempts.

Context: Joey Sr. accidentally assumes Phoebe is Chandler's wife, then Ross's wife, failing twice.

The Truth

Come Clean (Idiom): To confess to something; to stop hiding a secret.

Context: Joey demands his father 'come clean with Ma.'

A rainy window with a view of a city skyline, a wooden windowsill, a black flip phone, and a script page.

Cultural Nuance: “Waltons Mountain”

“Things sure have changed here on
Waltons Mountain.”

The Reference: The Waltons was a 1970s
TV show famous for portraying an incredibly
wholesome, morally perfect, deeply loving
rural family.

The Joke: Chandler uses extreme sarcasm.
By comparing Joey’s highly dysfunctional
family (affairs, restraining orders, open
secrets) to the most wholesome family in
television history, he creates comedic
contrast.

The Sitcom English Spectrum

How humor is created by colliding two different registers of English



Slang

Pee-pee
Boobies
Nuts
Sparky
0-for-2

Idioms

Tit for Tat
Come clean
Clear the tracks

Clinical

Intimacy issues
Emotionally stunted
Dysfunctional dynamic
Codependent



The Magic: When Chandler uses “-ular” (clinical) on “nipple” (casual), the collision creates the joke.

The Final Review: 10 Phrases to Keep

1. Unbeknownst to him
2. Avert your gaze
3. Tit for tat
4. Evening the score
5. Come clean
6. Not know someone from Adam
7. Keep at a distance
8. Textbook case
9. Air quotes
10. Emotionally stunted

Your Turn: Watch S1E13 and listen for the cues. Notice how the characters weaponize these words for comedy.